

NOTES TO MY KIDS (AND GRANDKIDS)

On My Personal Exploration of the

LAWS OF GOD'S LOVE

Volume 4: The Testing Protocol

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PREFACE

Volumes 1, 2, and 3 were explorations — the record of a journey that started in 2002 with a small workshop group at our church and grew, slowly and sometimes painfully, into a set of claims about how the spiritual world works. Those volumes are my best current answer to the question I have been asking since I came to Christ in my thirties: if God created a world that runs on regular, discoverable laws, then shouldn't His spiritual world run on regular, discoverable laws too?

Volume 4 is different. Volume 4 asks the harder question: how would we know?

That question is uncomfortable in church circles. We are not supposed to test God (Deut. 6:16). But there is a difference between testing God, demanding that He perform on our terms, and testing a framework for understanding how He works, to see whether the framework actually holds up in real people's lives over real time. The second kind of testing is not only permitted; it is commanded. "Test everything; hold fast what is good" (1 Thess. 5:21). "Dear friends, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits to see whether they are from God" (1 John 4:1).

C.S. Lewis adds a warning that belongs here, before the methodology is built. In *The Screwtape Letters*, he notes that the enemy's most effective counterfeits are not obvious falsehoods but near-truths, experiences, and impressions close enough to the genuine article that only a well-formed discernment can tell the difference. His implication is that the tester matters as much as the test: a person of immature character applying a rigorous methodology may still be reliably deceived, because the deception is calibrated to what rigorous but immature discernment will miss. This does not undermine the testing project; it contextualizes it. The protocols in the sections that follow are necessary but not sufficient. The researcher's own formation, their fear of the Lord, their community accountability, and their willingness to be wrong are not soft supplements to the methodology. It is a load-bearing part of the instrument.

This volume is my attempt to build a testing scaffolding for the Laws of the Spirit project, something rigorous enough to be taken seriously as a research program, and personal enough to be used by a small group of people meeting in someone's living room on a Thursday night. That is a hard combination to hold together. I am going to try.

Start here, with Sections 1 and 2. They lay the groundwork for what we mean by testing and how we will do it. The detailed protocols for individuals, small groups, and formal research come in the sections that follow.

Section 1: Why Testing Matters for the Laws of the Spirit Project

A Note on the Registry and the Calibration Cycle. The testing protocols in this volume are governed by Volume 6's calibration provisions. Every testable hypothesis here inherits its confidence from a specific Volume 1 or 2 claim. Testing results flow upward: when Volume 4 data bears on a Volume 1 or 2 claim, the annual calibration cycle described in Volume 6 formally adjusts that claim's confidence up or down based on the evidence. The disconfirmability standard (held at 95% confidence, the highest standard in this work) is the threshold for such adjustments. A proposed increase in confidence requires evidence consistent with the claim's stated disconfirming conditions not being met; a proposed decrease requires evidence that matches the conditions the claim itself specifies as disconfirming. Ad hoc confidence adjustments unsupported by disconfirmability-compliant evidence are not permitted. This discipline is how the whole work is meant to stay honest over time.

The Workshop Group as the Original Testing Community

The Laws of the Spirit project began with a testing community before it had any laws to test. When Amanda published the article in the church newsletter in January 2003, inviting people to join a workshop to explore whether God's spiritual world operates according to discoverable principles, three men responded: Tom, Larry, and John. The four of us committed to meeting regularly and to doing something unusual for a church Bible study: we agreed that we would not accept any principle as a Law of the Spirit unless it could be demonstrated — shown at work in our own lives and in scripture, discussed honestly, and refined through shared experience. If

one of us proposed a principle and the others could not confirm it from their own experience or from the text, it went back into the exploration pile.

That discipline was uncomfortable. It meant saying things like, "I don't see that" or "That hasn't been my experience" in a setting where we were all trying to grow spiritually. It meant being willing to be wrong in front of each other. But it produced something that a less disciplined exploration would not have produced: a set of claims that had survived genuine scrutiny from four different men with four different life histories.

That workshop group was, in the language of research methodology, a purposive sample with a structured peer-review process. I did not use those words at the time. But looking back, that is what it was. And it teaches me something important about how to build Volume 4: good testing of spiritual principles requires community. It cannot be done alone. The lone spiritual seeker, reading, praying, and journaling in isolation, may arrive at deep personal experience, but they cannot test whether that experience reflects a pattern that holds across persons, contexts, and time. Testing requires at least two witnesses (Matt. 18:16). It requires the friction of different perspectives. It requires being willing to be wrong.

Three Kinds of Testing — and Why All Three Are Needed

When I say that the LotS project needs testing, I mean three different things, and I want to be clear about which is which.

The first kind is personal and experiential testing. This is what the original workshop group did. It is what happens when someone reads Rom. 10:17, "faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ," and then pays close attention to whether that is actually how faith arrives in their own life. It is subjective. It is vulnerable to confirmation bias. It cannot be generalized beyond the person. But it is irreplaceable, because the Laws of the Spirit, if they are real, should be visible first in the lives of people who are seriously trying to live by them.

The second kind is small-group communal testing. This is what the workshop group was doing when it functioned at its best. It is what happens when five or six people commit to the same formation process — the same structured engagement with scripture, the same framework for understanding where they are in the journey — and then compare notes. Communal testing can detect patterns that personal testing cannot. If one person says, "I've noticed that my trust in scripture deepens after every significant trial," that is personal experience. If five people independently report the same pattern, and if that pattern maps onto Jas. 1:2–3's description of how tested faith produces steadfastness, something more interesting is happening. Communal testing is the LotS project's natural habitat.

The third kind is formal academic research. This is what I am building toward in the doctoral work at Liberty University. It requires operational definitions of constructs, validated instruments, controlled conditions, sufficient sample sizes, and statistical analysis. It is the slowest and most demanding kind of testing, and it cannot do everything; it cannot measure the movement of the Holy Spirit in a person's heart. But it can measure behavioral outcomes, stage progression, and the correlation between specific practices and specific results over time in ways the other two kinds of testing cannot. All three kinds are needed. They are not in competition; they are in conversation. The formal research should confirm what personal experience and communal discernment have already seen. And where it does not confirm them, that is data worth examining carefully.

What Would Count as Evidence Against a Claim?

The hardest question in the LotS testing program is the falsifiability question. A claim that cannot, even in principle, be shown to be false is not a testable claim. It is a statement of faith. Some of the LotS claims are, honestly, closer to statements of faith than to testable propositions, and I think that is appropriate. The existence of God, the reality of the Holy Spirit, the trustworthiness of scripture: these are presuppositions of the LotS project, not conclusions from it. I am not going to test whether God exists. I am going to test whether, given that God exists and that the Spirit is active, the specific mechanisms proposed in Volumes 1–3 produce the outcomes those volumes predict.

Let me give some concrete examples of what disconfirming evidence would look like for three specific claims.

Claim LotS-H3 states that heart formation is progressive and follows the five stages of the Affective Taxonomy. Disconfirming evidence would include: consistent failure to observe identifiable stage transitions in groups following the PROAPT model over time; random distribution of observable behaviors across stages with no directional pattern; or a pattern showing that people who engage in reflective bible study show no more stage progression than people who do not. If such patterns were consistently observed across multiple groups and multiple contexts, the claim would need revision.

Claim LotS-H4 states that reflective bible study is the primary discipline that advances heart formation at every stage. This claim draws from the MOVE study's finding (Hawkins & Parkinson, 2011) that reflective bible study is the one discipline present at every stage and every transition. Disconfirming evidence would include: a comparison study showing that groups engaged in other spiritual disciplines (prayer, service, worship) without reflective bible study show equal or greater stage progression than PROAPT groups; or evidence that the PROAPT model's specific structure (as opposed to any structured scripture engagement) makes no difference to outcomes.

Claim LotS-F3 states that trials are not interruptions to faith formation but the primary mechanism for stage transitions. Disconfirming evidence would include longitudinal data showing that people in stable, low-trial life circumstances exhibit equal or greater stage progression than those experiencing significant challenges; or narrative data from spiritual formation participants describing their most significant growth moments as exclusively associated with peaceful, undisturbed periods rather than with testing.

I am not expecting that evidence to appear. The claims are grounded in scripture and confirmed by the workshop group's experience and the academic literature. But I want the LotS project to be willing to look honestly at contrary evidence when it appears. A testing protocol that is designed only to confirm what it already believes is not a testing protocol. It is propaganda.

What Volume 4 Will and Will Not Do

Volume 4 will build a testing scaffolding for the spiritual formation claims at the heart of the LotS project. It will propose specific protocols for individual and small group testing. It will draft a design of a formal research program that could be implemented in a multi-site church study. It will draft the assessment instruments needed to operationalize the key constructs. And it will map the testing protocols back to the Open Trails identified in Volume 3, showing which trails this research program begins to explore.

Volume 4 will not prove that God is real, that the Spirit is active, or that scripture is trustworthy. Those are the foundations, not the conclusions, of the project. It will not claim that the proposed instruments are fully validated — they are drafts, ready for piloting and refinement. And it will not pretend that the spiritual formation journey can be fully captured in a measurement framework.

Some of what is most important in a person's growth with God is precisely what resists quantification: the moment of hearing the word with a new clarity, the quiet turning of the will in prayer, the sudden recognition of a character of Christ reflected in a neighbor's face. The measurement scaffolding is there to capture the traceable shadow of those moments, not to replace them.

With those limits stated honestly, let us build.

Discussion Questions for Small Groups

Section 1 Discussion Questions

- 1.** The original workshop group committed to not accepting any principle unless it could be demonstrated through shared experience and scripture. What would it mean to bring that same discipline to your current small group or Bible study? What would have to change?
 - 2.** I distinguish three kinds of testing: personal/experiential, small group communal, and formal academic research. Which of the three have you experienced in your own spiritual formation? Which feels most foreign, and why?
 - 3.** What would count as disconfirming evidence for a spiritual principle that you currently hold? Is there a belief about how God works that you would be willing to revise if the evidence pointed in a different direction? What would that evidence need to look like?
 - 4.** I say that testing God (Deuteronomy 6:16) and testing a framework for understanding how God works are different things. Do you agree with that distinction? Where is the line between demanding that God perform and honestly testing whether a proposed mechanism produces the outcomes it predicts?
 - 5.** Volume 4 acknowledges that some of the most important moments of spiritual formation resist quantification. How do you hold together the discipline of honest testing with the humility required to recognize that some of what God does cannot be measured?
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Section 2: Testing Framework — Epistemological Foundations

Four Sources, One Exploration

The Laws of the Spirit project has always drawn from four sources: scripture, reason, experience, and community. Readers who are familiar with the Wesleyan tradition will recognize the structure — it maps closely onto what has come to be called the Wesleyan Quadrilateral (scripture, tradition, reason, experience), with the LotS substitution of community for tradition. That substitution is intentional and worth explaining because it affects how we design the testing framework.

Tradition is the accumulated wisdom of the church across centuries, a powerful resource for any theological exploration. But tradition has a particular limitation for a project like the LotS: it can tell us what others have believed about the spiritual life, but it cannot show us the spiritual life happening in the room tonight, in this group, with these people. The community can do that. The workshop group's willingness to bring their own experience to the table, to say "here is what I observed in my own life this week," gave the exploration a living laboratory that no amount of reading the Fathers could provide. And community also provides the accountability that personal experience alone lacks: other people can see things in us that we cannot see in ourselves.

What does each source contribute to the testing framework, and what are its limits without the others?

Scripture is the non-negotiable foundation. Every proposed Law of the Spirit must be grounded in the biblical text, not just plausibly consistent with it, but clearly taught by it. Scripture alone, however, is not enough for testing: the history of the church is littered with interpretive disagreements among people who were all reading the same text with equal sincerity. Scripture needs reason, experience, and community to be received rightly.

Reason provides the interpretive and analytical tools to handle scripture carefully, to build coherent frameworks, and to identify logical inconsistencies in proposed laws. The Affective Taxonomy is a product of reason applied to human learning, and its application to heart formation in the LotS project is itself a reasoned move, not a scriptural one. Reason alone, however, is the most dangerous source in spiritual exploration: it can construct beautiful, internally consistent systems that are completely disconnected from the actual life of the Spirit. My engineer's instinct, that the system should be tight and elegant, needs to be constantly checked against the messiness of real human experience.

Experience is where the rubber meets the road. A proposed law that is scripturally grounded and logically coherent but that nobody has ever actually observed operating in human life should be held with suspicion. Experience is the first testing community. But experience is also the most vulnerable to distortion, to confirmation bias, to the human tendency to notice what we are looking for, to the difficulty of distinguishing the Spirit's movement from our own emotional state. Experience needs community to correct it and scripture to anchor it.

Community provides the interpersonal friction that the other three sources cannot provide on their own. Community is where proposed laws are tested against multiple life histories simultaneously. It is where the person who has not experienced what the law predicts can honestly say so. It is where the person who has experienced something dramatic can have that experience examined by others who love them enough to ask hard questions. The PROAPT model's 'Tell' step, where each member shares what happened and who they will tell, is a community testing mechanism built into the formation process itself.

I want to be clear about one risk in my substitution of community for tradition. Tradition's particular value is that it cannot be captured by the blind spots of a present community, it reaches across centuries and carries the weight of correction that our particular time and context cannot generate on its own. Grudem's concern about charismatic communities that trust their own Spirit-witness without sufficient engagement with historical orthodoxy is a fair warning, and the original workshop group was not immune to it. I am not reversing my substitution, but I want to add a methodological note: the testing protocol should include a deliberate step in which proposed laws are checked not just against scripture and community experience but against the major streams of the historical church's formation theology, particularly the Desert Fathers, the medieval mystics, the Reformation tradition, and the Wesleyan and Pentecostal streams. If a proposed law has no recognition anywhere in two thousand years of Christian experience, that absence is data worth examining seriously before proceeding.

Quantitative and Qualitative: Choosing the Right Tool

One of the most important early decisions in designing the LotS testing program is distinguishing which claims are primarily quantitative and which are primarily qualitative. This is not a binary; most complex human phenomena yield both kinds of data. But the distinction shapes instrument design, analysis strategy, and the kind of conclusions that can legitimately be drawn.

Some LotS claims predict outcomes that are, at least in principle, countable or rankable: stage transitions on the Affective Taxonomy, frequency of scripture engagement, measurable changes in epistemic trust scores over time, and behavioral changes observable to external witnesses. These are quantitative in nature. A person who moves from Stage 2 (Responding) to Stage 3 (Valuing) of the Affective Taxonomy should show observable behavioral changes — not just reporting that they value scripture more highly, but organizing their schedule differently, making costly choices in alignment with biblical principles, bringing the word to bear on real life decisions in a way that others around them can observe. That kind of change can be assessed, at least approximately, with well-designed instruments.

Other LotS claims predict outcomes that resist quantification: the deepening of discernment, the growing clarity of the image of God in a person as experienced by those around them, and the quality of a person's relationship with God. These are qualitative in nature. A person at Stage 4 (Organization) on the Affective Taxonomy is not just doing more of what they were doing at Stage 2, they are operating from a reorganized value system, seeing the world through a different lens, making meaning differently. That kind of change requires narrative data to capture: stories told in the person's own words, observed by people who know them well, documented over time.

The proposed testing program for the LotS project is therefore a mixed-methods design by necessity, not by methodological fashion. To illustrate what that looks like in practice: a mixed-methods study of LotS-H3 (heart formation is progressive and follows the Affective Taxonomy stages) would combine a quantitative component, administering the Personal Spiritual Formation Assessment at baseline, six months, and twelve months, looking for statistically significant stage progression in PROAPT groups compared to control groups, with a qualitative component: monthly narrative reflection entries from each participant, coded by trained researchers for evidence of stage-characteristic language, behaviors, and meaning-making patterns. The quantitative data would tell us whether movement is occurring. The qualitative data would tell us what that movement actually looks like from the inside, and would capture the transition moments, the specific experiences of testing, conviction, and surrender that mark the shift from one stage to the next.

The Hidden Variable: The Holy Spirit

Every serious researcher of Christian spiritual formation faces a methodological problem that secular developmental psychology does not: the agent of transformation in the LotS framework is not primarily the PROAPT model, the Affective Taxonomy, or the facilitator's skill. It is the Holy Spirit, active, personal, and uncontrollable. John 3:8 "The wind blows where it wishes, and you hear its sound, but you do not know where it comes from or where it is going" is not just a theological statement; it is a methodological warning. The Spirit is the primary independent variable in the formation process, and it is not a variable any researcher can control, manipulate, or measure directly.

This is a genuine problem. But it is a manageable one, if approached honestly. I want to propose three ways of handling the Holy Spirit as a research variable.

First, acknowledge it as a foundational presupposition. The LotS testing program does not attempt to explain the Spirit's role away by attributing all formation outcomes to psychological or social mechanisms. The claim is not that PROAPT produces heart formation through purely natural mechanisms. The claim is that PROAPT creates the conditions in which the Spirit characteristically works, conditions of attentiveness, humility, community, and engagement with the word. The research tests whether those conditions produce the predicted outcomes. It leaves the causation of those outcomes, at the deepest level, appropriately open.

Second, treat Spirit-prompted events as data rather than noise. In a conventional experimental design, dramatic unexpected events, sudden convictions, powerful emotional responses to scripture, experiences of hearing God's voice, would be treated as outliers or confounds. In the LotS testing framework, they are among the most interesting data points. Open Trail OT-5 asks whether revivals and dramatic conversion experiences require some prior heart preparation. The Narrative Reflection Protocol is designed, in part, to capture these moments and examine what preceded them. Did the person experience a period of unusual attentiveness to scripture? Was there a specific trial that had been softening the ground? What were the precursors? The Spirit is not random; I'm suggesting that He tends to work in the context of the conditions the LotS project is trying to understand.

Third, use the researcher's own spiritual formation as a calibration instrument. This is unconventional in academic research, but it is entirely consistent with the LotS tradition. The original workshop group was testing the laws from the inside, all four members were themselves living the journey they were studying. A researcher who is personally engaged in PROAPT practice, who has a spiritual director or supervisor, and who is paying close attention to their own formation is better positioned to recognize what they are observing in their research participants. This is not a license for the researcher to project their own experience onto the data. It is a recognition that some things in the spiritual life are only visible to someone who has been there.

Construct Validity: Measuring What We Mean

A testing program is only as good as the clarity of its constructs. If we say we are measuring "heart formation," we need to be precise about what that means, precise enough that two different researchers, using the same definition, would make the same assessment when observing the same participant. This is the construct validity problem, and it is particularly acute for spiritual formation research because the key constructs (heart, spirit, faith, trust, love) have rich theological meanings that resist simple operationalization.

The LotS project has several advantages here that most spiritual formation research frameworks do not. The Affective Taxonomy provides a detailed, multi-stage model of affective

development with specific behavioral indicators for each level. The theological anthropology of Volumes 1–3 provides a definition of the heart as the affective center of the person, the site of emotions, will, moral choices, and desire for God, corresponding to the Hebrew *leb*, which grounds the construct in both scriptural and anthropological terms. And the Image of God framework provides four concrete developmental domains (Reason, Rulership, Relationship, Righteousness) that can be assessed individually.

The epistemic trust research of Campbell et al. (2021) is particularly useful here. Their work defines and validates a multi-dimensional construct of trust in communicated knowledge, with three dimensions: trust, mistrust, and credulity. They connect these dimensions to attachment theory: a person with a secure relational attachment style tends to engage with trusted sources (including scripture) with clear, balanced trust, neither defensively rejecting nor uncritically accepting. The LotS Scripture Trust Index, adapted from their instrument, will measure the trust dimension specifically, tracking movement along the continuum from "this is just a collection of old fables" to full integration into a personal biblical worldview, which is exactly Barna's (2003) Stage 5 endpoint.

Hall's (2017) Spiritual Transformation Inventory (STI), administered to over 28,000 students in more than forty Christian colleges, organizes spiritual formation into five domains: connection to God, connection to self and others, connection to a spiritual community, connection to spiritual practices, and connection to God's Kingdom. These five domains map closely onto the LotS framework and provide a validated reference structure. The LotS instruments will borrow selectively from the STI while adding the Affective Taxonomy stage structure and the Image of God 4Rs as additional dimensions.

Hawkins and Parkinson's (2011) MOVE study contributes one of the most important construct validity anchors in the LotS testing program: the empirical identification of four distinguishable growth stages with three observable transition movements. Their finding that reflective bible study is the one discipline present at every stage and every transition gives us both a quantitative prediction (PROAPT groups should show stage progression; non-PROAPT groups, holding other variables constant, should show less) and a qualitative prediction (stage transitions should be associated with deepened engagement with scripture, not merely with increased time in any spiritual activity).

The NCD Church Survey, developed by Christian Schwarz through NCD International, provides a third empirical reference point that fills a gap left open by the STI and MOVE studies: community-level health measurement. The Survey has been administered to more than 70,000 churches across 84 countries and 112 denominations, making it the most internationally and interdenominationally validated instrument in Christian community health research. Its construct validity methodology is worth examining closely: the Survey diagnoses health across eight quality characteristics, identifies the single "minimum factor" the weakest characteristic that functions as a rate-limiting variable and tracks improvement after targeted intervention in that area. This is a different kind of construct validity claim from the LotS instruments, but a complementary one. Where the MOVE study validates the existence of distinguishable individual growth stages and the STI validates the epistemic trust construct, the NCD Survey validates the claim that community health qualities are empirically distinguishable, measurable, and responsive to targeted intervention.

The limitation is important to name honestly: the NCD Survey is designed for the church organism as a whole, not for small groups or individual formation. It cannot be imported directly into the Vol 4 protocol. But the minimum-factor diagnostic logic, identify the rate-limiting variable, intervene there first, track whether removing that constraint produces disproportionate gains, is worth borrowing for the small-group health assessment in Section 4, and the Survey's

international validation record provides the closest existing model for the eventual cross-cultural reach of the LotS testing program.

Hodge's (2005) multidimensional framework for spiritual assessment, developed for social workers, rounds out the epistemological foundation by providing a model of holistic spiritual well-being that integrates cognitive, affective, behavioral, and relational dimensions. His review of both qualitative and quantitative assessment tools gives the LotS testing program a methodological bridge between the clinical research tradition and the theological formation tradition.

The Researcher's Own Formation as a Methodological and Ethical Consideration

I want to close this section with something that is not standard in academic research methodology but that belongs in any honest account of how to test the Laws of the Spirit: the requirement that the researcher be on the journey.

The LotS project has always insisted that you cannot study the spiritual life from the outside. This is not just a theological claim, it is a phenomenological one. There are things about Stage 4 of the Affective Taxonomy, about what it looks like and feels like when a person begins to organize their entire value system around biblical principles, that are only fully intelligible to someone who has been through that transition. There are things about hearing the voice of God, about the difference between the Spirit's whisper and one's own wishful thinking, that require a calibrated interior instrument to detect. That instrument is a human being who is themselves practicing attentiveness to the Spirit, who is receiving formation, who has a community that tells them the truth.

This creates both a methodological advantage and an ethical responsibility. The methodological advantage is that formed researchers bring a kind of pattern recognition to the data that untrained observers cannot. The ethical responsibility is that this same proximity creates the risk of confirmation bias and projection. The safeguard is not to remove the researcher from their own formation journey, that would be both impossible and counterproductive. The safeguard is to name the assumption explicitly, to build in external checks (peer review, supervision, the External Witness Interview), and to treat the researcher's own formation journey as a variable to be disclosed and accounted for, not hidden.

This is, finally, why the LotS project has always needed a community to carry it. No single researcher, not even one who is a serious practitioner, can hold all the necessary perspectives simultaneously. The testing program proposed in the sections that follow is designed for a team: a formation facilitator, a research coordinator, a group of participants willing to be observed, and a set of external witnesses who can see what those on the inside cannot. That is not a research design constraint. That is the LotS project being true to itself.

Discussion Questions for Small Groups

Section 2 Discussion Questions

1. The LotS project draws from four sources: scripture, reason, experience, and community. Which of the four do you personally lean on most heavily? Which do you most neglect? What would it look like to bring them into better balance in your own spiritual exploration?

2. The author argues that the Holy Spirit should be treated as a foundational presupposition of the research, not a confounding variable to be explained away. How do you respond to that framing? Does it seem like intellectual honesty or intellectual evasion?
3. Construct validity requires that we be precise about what we mean by "heart formation" or "trust in scripture." How would you define one of these constructs in your own words — precisely enough that someone who did not know you could use your definition to observe it in another person's life?
4. The author argues that researchers of the spiritual life need to be on the journey themselves — that you cannot study spiritual formation from the outside. Do you agree? What are the advantages and risks of that posture?
5. Sections 1 and 2 together lay the epistemological foundation for the testing program. Before moving to the specific protocols in Sections 3–5, what questions do you most want those protocols to answer? What would you most need to see — or not see — in the data, for the LotS framework to earn your trust?

Section 3: Individual Spiritual Formation Testing Protocol

Starting with the Person in the Room

Every research program about spiritual formation has to make a choice about its unit of analysis. You can study churches, denominations, small groups, or individuals. The LotS project starts with the individual, not because community does not matter (it matters enormously, and Section 4 addresses small group testing directly), but because the heart that is being formed is a single heart. The Holy Spirit convicts one person at a time. The word of Christ lands in one person's hearing at a time. The Affective Taxonomy traces a journey that one person makes, stage by stage, even when they make it in the company of others.

The individual testing protocol is also where the LotS project stays most honest about what it can and cannot claim. A person's spiritual formation is complex, non-linear, and influenced by factors that no research design can fully account for: their family of origin, their prior experience of church, the quality of their current relationships, the trials they are walking through, the particular voice and character of the Spirit's work in their specific life. The protocol proposed here does not pretend to control for all of those variables. It is designed to observe the journey closely enough, over a long enough period of time, that patterns can emerge, and to capture both the patterns and the texture of what the journey actually feels like from the inside.

3a. Defining the Testing Unit

The individual testing unit for the LotS spiritual formation protocol is a person who meets four criteria. First, they are a self-identified Christian who takes the spiritual life seriously, not necessarily a mature or advanced disciple, but someone who genuinely wants to grow. The testing protocol is not designed for people who are indifferent to formation; it is designed to observe and support formation in people who have at least a Stage 1 or Stage 2 relationship to the journey (Receiving or Responding on the Affective Taxonomy). Second, they are willing to participate in a PROAPT small group meeting weekly for a minimum of twelve months. Third, they are willing to complete regular self-assessments and to allow their progress to be observed and documented. And fourth, they are willing to identify an external witness, a family member, close friend, or coworker who knows them well, who can be interviewed at the beginning and end of the study period.

The twelve-month minimum is important and deliberate. Stage transitions on the Affective Taxonomy are not quick events, they are more like tectonic shifts than lightning strikes. The research at Willow Creek (Hawkins & Parkinson, 2011) found that movement between spiritual growth stages typically takes years, not months, in the absence of structured formation support. The hypothesis of the LotS testing program is that the PROAPT model, applied consistently in a supportive community, can accelerate that movement, but "accelerated" in this context still means observable change over twelve months, not overnight transformation. The protocol is designed to be long enough to capture real movement while remaining feasible for church-based research.

3b. Assessing the Starting State

Before the formation process begins, each participant completes a baseline assessment designed to establish their starting position on four dimensions. These dimensions are not independent of each other, growth in one tends to support growth in the others, but each captures something distinct, and tracking them separately over time allows the research to detect which aspects of formation are progressing, which are lagging, and where the next growth edge lies.

Dimension 1: Affective Taxonomy Stage

The baseline Affective Taxonomy stage is assessed through a combination of self-report and facilitator observation. The self-report component draws from the Personal Spiritual Formation Assessment (PSFA), which is drafted in Appendix A of this volume. The PSFA asks the participant to respond to stage-characteristic behavioral statements, statements that describe what a person at each stage of the Affective Taxonomy typically does, says, and values, and to rate their degree of honest recognition in each. The facilitator observation component adds an outside perspective: the group facilitator, using the Group Affective Taxonomy Assessment described in Section 4, documents their initial impression of each participant's stage based on their first few sessions of observation.

Determining a person's starting stage is an interpretive act, not a precise measurement. Most people are not purely at one stage; they show behaviors characteristic of multiple adjacent stages. The practice in the LotS protocol is to identify the highest stage at which the participant shows consistent, habitual patterns, not occasional flickers, and to record that as the baseline stage. Movement is then defined as the emergence of consistent, habitual patterns at the next stage.

Affective Taxonomy Stages — Quick Reference for Assessors

Stage 1 — Receiving: Awareness, willingness to attend. Shows up to the group. Listens without consistent engagement.

Stage 2 — Responding: Beginning intellectual and emotional reaction. Answers factual questions, asks follow-ups, and engages with the discussion. Scripture is interesting.

Stage 3 — Valuing: Beginning to live according to biblical teachings. Observable behavior changes. Personal prayer requests, repentance in the group. Scripture costs something.

Stage 4 — Organization: Organizing life decisions around biblical principles. Consistent patterns visible to outsiders. Scripture shapes the whole structure of daily life.

Stage 5 — Characterization: Barna's (2003) biblical worldview is fully evident. Character, not just behavior, is shaped by Christ. Pain is accepted as part of submission to God. Moving from hearing about God to seeing him (Job 42:5).

Dimension 2: Scripture Trust

The baseline Scripture Trust Index (STI-A, adapted from Campbell et al., 2021) measures where the participant sits on the trust continuum, from no trust in scripture as authoritative or reliable, through intellectual acknowledgment without personal application, through active engagement and partial trust, to full integration of scripture as the organizing principle of life and worldview. The STI-A is a 12-item self-report instrument; its draft is included in Appendix A.

The trust dimension is particularly important to establish at baseline because it predicts the participant's capacity to engage productively with the PROAPT process. A person at the low-trust end of the continuum can still participate in the group and benefit from the community, but the specific mechanism of Romans 10:17 (faith coming from hearing the word of Christ) will only begin to operate as trust in the word develops. Baseline STI-A scores help the facilitator calibrate their approach: a group with several low-trust participants needs more time in the early PROAPT stages (Pray, Read, Observe) and more patience with questions before moving to Apply.

Dimension 3: Image of God Reflection

The Image of God 4Rs Self-Assessment asks the participant to rate their current experience of each of Kilner's (2015) four dimensions of reflection: Reason (the mind brought into alignment with God's truth), Rulership (responsible stewardship of their sphere of influence), Relationship (depth of connection with God and others), and Righteousness (habitual alignment of character with God's character). The instrument is designed to produce a simple profile, a snapshot of where the participant currently sees themselves growing and where they feel most distant from the reflection of Christ in their life.

This baseline profile serves two purposes. First, it gives the participant and facilitator a common language for discussing formation goals, rather than the vague aspiration to "grow spiritually," the 4Rs framework invites a more specific conversation: which dimension is most alive in this person right now, and which is most dormant? Second, it provides an endpoint comparison at twelve months: has the profile shifted? Which R has shown the most growth? Does the pattern of growth map onto what the Affective Taxonomy stages would predict?

Dimension 4: Spiritual Disciplines Frequency

The Spiritual Disciplines Frequency Log (SDFL) establishes a baseline count of the participant's current engagement with key formation practices: personal bible reading (frequency and duration), personal prayer (frequency and character, conversational, structured, contemplative), participation in corporate worship, service to others, and fasting or other ascetic practices. This is the most straightforwardly quantitative of the four baseline dimensions, and it provides the context for interpreting changes in the other three.

The SDFL is not designed to assess the quality of these practices, a person can read their bible every day and still be at Stage 2 of the Affective Taxonomy if the reading is purely cognitive and the word is never landing in the heart. But frequency data is a useful starting point, and it becomes more meaningful when correlated with the other dimensions over time. A participant who shows significant stage progression without any change in discipline frequency is saying something interesting about the mechanism of formation. A participant whose discipline frequency doubles with no corresponding stage progression is saying something equally interesting.

3c. The Primary Outcome Variables

The testing protocol tracks four primary outcome variables over the twelve-month period. They correspond to the four dimensions assessed at baseline, and together they provide a multi-dimensional picture of individual spiritual formation progress.

Outcome Variable 1: Affective Taxonomy Stage Progression

The primary outcome variable is measurable movement from one Affective Taxonomy stage to the next, or identifiable deepening within a stage. Not every participant will show a full stage transition in twelve months, particularly participants who begin at Stage 3 or Stage 4, where the transitions are deeper, slower, and more costly. But every participant should show some movement: either a stage transition, a deepening of habitual behaviors within their current stage, or the emergence of Stage N+1 behaviors alongside their current Stage N baseline.

Stage transitions are identified by the co-occurrence of three indicators: (1) the participant themselves reports, in their Narrative Reflection Protocol entries, a shift in how scripture lands, not just more interesting but more personally binding; (2) the facilitator observes a change in the participant's group behavior, specifically, the kind of sharing they are willing to do, the personal risks they take in applying the word, the way they speak about God; and (3) an external witness reports observable changes in the participant's behavior, character, or relationships that they attribute to the participant's spiritual engagement.

The three-indicator requirement is demanding. It is deliberately so. A stage transition in the Affective Taxonomy is not a mood shift or a momentary resolve. It is a restructuring of the person's value system, the kind of change that Paul describes in Rom. 12:2 as a renewing of the mind, and that Jesus describes in the parable of the Sower (Matthew 13) as the word taking deep root and bearing fruit. That kind of change leaves multiple traces. Requiring three independent indicators before recording a stage transition protects the protocol against false positives.

Stage Transition	Primary Behavioral Indicators
Stage 1 → 2	Moves from passive attendance to active engagement; asks questions; shows emotional response to scripture; begins applying observations to their own life in group discussion.
Stage 2 → 3	Reports observable behavior changes outside the group; brings prayer requests reflecting personal conviction; begins to speak of scripture as personally authoritative, not just intellectually interesting; willingness to repent publicly in the group.
Stage 3 → 4	Life-structuring decisions made on biblical principles, visible to external witnesses; consistent discipline patterns; testimony of scripture shaping major choices (relationships, finances, vocation); others seek their wisdom.
Stage 4 → 5	Character matches behavior — not just doing the right things but being the right person; response to suffering reflects Job 2:9 / 42:5 movement; uninstructed acts of love and sacrifice; no gap between public and private life as reported by external witness.

Outcome Variable 2: Scripture Trust Index Score

The STI-A is administered at baseline, at six months, and at twelve months. A meaningful positive change is defined as a movement of one or more points on the overall trust scale, accompanied by qualitative narrative evidence (in the NRP entries) of the specific experiences or encounters with scripture that drove the change. Score change without narrative evidence is recorded but not interpreted as meaningful stage-level progress; the LotS framework predicts that genuine trust development is always associated with specific moments of hearing, specific encounters with the word that cut through in a new way.

The STI-A score also serves as a check on the Affective Taxonomy stage assessment. The two measures should move in the same direction: a person who is progressing on the Affective Taxonomy should show increasing scripture trust, and a person who shows increasing scripture trust should be progressing on the Affective Taxonomy. Where the two measures diverge, a person showing behavioral stage progression but declining scripture trust, for example, the discrepancy is a research flag that invites qualitative investigation. What is happening in this person's relationship to the word that is producing behavioral change without deepening trust?

Outcome Variable 3: Image of God 4Rs Profile Shift

The Image of God 4Rs Self-Assessment is administered at baseline and at twelve months. A meaningful shift is defined as a change of two or more points on any single R dimension, or a change in the overall profile that reflects a new balance between the four dimensions. Because the 4Rs are an endpoint description (the shape of the reflection of Christ), they are expected to change more slowly than the Affective Taxonomy stage. A person can be progressing through the early Affective Taxonomy stages without yet showing strong growth in all four Rs. But a person approaching Stage 4 or 5 should show robust growth in at least two Rs, and the specific Rs showing growth should map predictably onto their PROAPT experience: a group that has spent significant time in passages about prayer and relationship with God should show growth in the Relationship R; a group that has wrestled with justice and stewardship passages should show growth in the Rulership R.

Outcome Variable 4: Integration of Belief and Behavior

One of the most reliable indicators of Stage 3 formation, and one of the most interesting research variables in the LotS testing program, is the narrowing of the gap between what a person says they believe and what they actually do. A person at Stage 2 can articulate biblical principles with precision while their life is organized around entirely different values. A person at Stage 3 is beginning to feel the cost of that gap, which is why Stage 3 is the stage of personal conviction, repentance, and the first costly behavioral changes. A person at Stage 4 has substantially closed the gap: their life and their beliefs are organized around the same center.

The integration variable is assessed primarily through the External Witness Interview: the person outside the group who knows the participant best is asked, without knowing the participant's self-report scores, to describe the consistency they observe between what the participant says they believe and how they actually live. The EWI question is not asked abstractly; it is grounded in specific observable behaviors: how does the participant handle conflict? How do they talk about money? How do they treat people who cannot help them? What do they do when no one is watching? External witnesses are often the most honest assessors of the belief-behavior gap, because they see the participant in the unguarded moments of daily life that the research group never observes.

3d. The Four Assessment Instruments

The individual testing protocol uses four instruments, each targeting a different dimension of the formation journey. Their drafts appear in Appendix A; what follows here is a description of their purpose, their relationship to the LotS framework, and the principles guiding their use.

Instrument 1: Personal Spiritual Formation Assessment (PSFA)

The PSFA is a 25-item self-report instrument that assesses the participant's current position on the Affective Taxonomy and their self-perceived growth in the Image of God 4Rs. It is the primary quantitative instrument of the individual testing protocol. The PSFA draws from Hall's (2017) Spiritual Transformation Inventory in its structure — five domains, each with sub-items — while replacing Hall's five domains with the LotS framework's Affective Taxonomy stages (five levels) and adding a second section on the 4Rs (four dimensions, four items each).

The PSFA is administered at baseline, six months, and twelve months. Participants are asked to respond to each item on a five-point scale from "This does not describe me" to "This describes me consistently and habitually." The five-point scale is chosen deliberately to discourage the middle response and to force a direction. The items themselves are written as behavioral and experiential descriptions — not as belief statements ("I believe scripture is true") but as formation statements ("When I read scripture, I find myself making specific changes to my behavior in response"). This is consistent with the Affective Taxonomy's focus on the affective dimension of learning, which is always manifest in behavior and disposition, not just in cognition.

Instrument 2: Scripture Trust Index — Adapted (STI-A)

The STI-A is a 12-item self-report instrument adapted from Campbell et al.'s (2021) epistemic trust measure for use in a Christian spiritual formation context. The original instrument measures trust in communicated knowledge in a therapeutic relationship; the LotS adaptation replaces the therapist with scripture as the trusted source and recalibrates the items to reflect the specific dimensions of trust in the biblical text: trust in its reliability, in its personal applicability, in its authority over life decisions, and in its sufficiency as a guide.

The STI-A measures only the trust dimension of Campbell et al.'s three-dimensional construct (trust, mistrust, credulity), because trust is the dimension that maps directly onto the Affective Taxonomy's progression. Credulity — uncritical acceptance of anything claimed in the name of scripture — is not a formation goal; it is a spiritual vulnerability. The STI-A includes two items designed to detect credulity as a possible ceiling effect: a participant who scores very high on trust but also high on credulity items is not at Stage 5 of the Affective Taxonomy; they may be at an immature Stage 2 or 3 where enthusiasm has not yet been tested.

Instrument 3: Narrative Reflection Protocol (NRP)

The NRP is the qualitative heart of the individual testing protocol. Each month, the participant responds to four structured reflection prompts in a private journal format. The prompts are designed to surface the specific experiences and encounters that the LotS framework predicts will drive formation: encounters with the word, experiences of testing, moments of heart change, and evidence of Image of God growth.

The four monthly prompts are: (1) Describe a specific moment this month when the word of Christ landed in a new way — when you heard it differently than you had before. What were the circumstances? What changed? (2) Describe a trial or difficulty you encountered this month. In retrospect, how did it affect your trust in God and your engagement with scripture? (3) Describe one specific way your heart changed this month — a shift in what you value, what you desire, what you fear, or what you love. (4) Identify one area where the image of God in you became slightly clearer this month — one of the 4Rs showing a new edge of growth. What made it visible to you?

The NRP entries are not shared with the research team in real time — they are collected at the end of the twelve-month period, with the participant's permission, for qualitative coding. This protects the formation process from becoming a performance: the participant writes for themselves and for God, not for the researcher. At the twelve-month endpoint, the participant reviews their own NRP entries before their final interview, identifying the moments they consider most significant. This review process is itself a formation exercise — a version of the Ignatian Examen applied to a year of documented spiritual journey.

Instrument 4: Spiritual Disciplines Frequency Log (SDFL)

The SDFL is a simple weekly log — one page per month — on which the participant records the frequency and approximate duration of five categories of spiritual practice: personal bible reading and study, personal prayer, participation in the PROAPT small group, participation in corporate worship, and acts of service or giving. The SDFL is designed to take less than five minutes per week to complete; if it takes longer, it has been over-designed.

The SDFL is the least theoretically interesting of the four instruments — frequency counts alone tell you almost nothing about formation. But frequency data becomes interpretively rich when correlated with the PSFA stage assessments and the NRP narratives. The SDFL answers the question: under what conditions of practice did this person's formation occur? A participant who shows significant stage progression with low and irregular discipline frequency is an interesting anomaly that invites investigation. A participant whose discipline frequency is high but whose stage progression is flat is pointing toward the most important distinction in the LotS framework: the difference between doing the practices and allowing the word to land in the heart.

3e. The Testing Timeline

The twelve-month individual testing protocol is organized into three phases. The phases are not arbitrary divisions; they correspond to the characteristic formation dynamics of the early, middle, and later stages of the Affective Taxonomy journey.

Phase 1 — Orientation and Baseline (Months 1–3)

The first three months are foundational. The participant completes the full baseline assessment — PSFA, STI-A, Image of God 4Rs Self-Assessment, and initial SDFL — in the first week. They attend their first PROAPT group sessions and begin to find their footing in the structured bible study rhythm. The facilitator pays close attention during this phase to where each participant is starting: which participants seem to be at Stage 1 (attending, listening, orienting), which are at Stage 2 (engaging intellectually, asking questions), and which are already showing Stage 3 behaviors (applying the word at personal cost).

The NRP begins in Month 1. Many participants will find the early prompts difficult — not because the questions are hard, but because they have never been asked to document their spiritual experience in this specific way. The facilitator should offer encouragement and normalize the awkwardness: the first few months of NRP entries are expected to be the thinnest and most generic, and that itself is data about where the participant is starting.

Phase 1 is also the phase most vulnerable to dropout. Participants who are at Stage 1 — attending out of curiosity or social obligation — may find the commitment level of weekly PROAPT plus monthly NRP higher than they expected. The research protocol should include a check-in conversation at the end of Month 3, giving every participant the opportunity to ask questions, voice concerns, and either recommit or gracefully withdraw before the active formation phase begins.

Phase 2 — Active Formation (Months 4–9)

The middle six months are where the work happens. The PROAPT group is now past the initial awkwardness and into a rhythm of genuine engagement with scripture. The NRP entries should begin to show more specificity — particular passages that struck hard, particular trials that shook something loose, particular moments of unexpected heart change. The SDFL data should show whether the participant's discipline patterns are stabilizing or still erratic.

Two formal assessment points fall within Phase 2. At Month 6, the PSFA and STI-A are administered again — not announced as a major assessment event but built into the group's normal rhythm as a natural midpoint check-in. The facilitator reviews each participant's Month 6 scores against their baseline and uses the results to inform their facilitation approach for the second half of the study: participants who are showing clear movement need challenge and deepening; participants who seem stuck need gentle investigation of what may be blocking movement.

The most important formation events of the entire protocol typically occur during Phase 2. The LotS framework predicts, drawing from James 1:2–3 and from the MOVE study's finding about trials as transition catalysts, that the Stage 2-to-3 transition — the movement from intellectual engagement to personal commitment — is almost always associated with a specific challenge or cost. Something happens in Phase 2: a relationship strained, a financial decision made on biblical principle at personal cost, a conviction that requires a public acknowledgment or apology. The NRP is designed to catch these moments. The facilitator's session observation notes are designed to detect when they are approaching.

Phase 3 — Integration and Assessment (Months 10–12)

The final three months shift from primarily formative to also evaluative. The participant's NRP entries during this phase should have a different quality than the earlier ones — more reflective, more integrated, more aware of the arc of the year. The SDFL data from these months provides the endpoint picture of the participant's discipline patterns.

At Month 12, the full assessment battery is administered: PSFA, STI-A, and Image of God 4Rs Self-Assessment. The participant reviews their own twelve months of NRP entries before their endpoint interview and identifies the three moments they consider most significant in their formation during the year. The endpoint interview with the research coordinator is semi-structured, following a protocol that allows the participant to tell the story of their year in their own terms before the researcher asks specific questions about stage progression, scripture trust, and Image of God growth.

The External Witness Interview is conducted in Month 12, independent of the participant's own assessment. The external witness is not told what the participant's self-assessment scores are; they are asked only to describe what they have observed in the participant over the past year. The convergence or divergence between the external witness's observations and the participant's self-report is one of the most interesting data points in the entire protocol — and one of the most telling indicators of whether genuine Stage 4 integration has occurred.

3f. The Claims This Protocol Tests

The individual testing protocol is designed primarily to test four of the LotS claims identified across Volumes 1–3:

LotS-H3 — Heart formation is progressive and follows the five stages of the Affective Taxonomy. The protocol tests this by tracking stage-characteristic behaviors over twelve

months in a structured formation context. If the claim holds, PROAPT participants should show directional stage progression that is not observed in comparable non-PROAPT participants.

LotS-H4 — Reflective bible study (PROAPT model) is the primary discipline that advances heart formation at every stage. The protocol tests this through the SDFL frequency data and the NRP narratives, looking for the association between PROAPT engagement and formation movement predicted by the MOVE study (Hawkins & Parkinson, 2011).

LotS-F2 — Faith is primarily affective, not cognitive. The protocol tests this by examining whether stage progression is associated with changes in the heart dimensions of the PSFA (affect, will, desire) before changes in the cognitive dimensions (knowledge, understanding), as the LotS framework predicts.

LotS-I2 — Spiritual formation is growth in reflection of the image of God, measurable through the 4Rs. The protocol tests this through the Image of God 4Rs Self-Assessment at baseline and twelve months, looking for profile shifts that correspond to stage progression and to the specific scriptural content engaged through PROAPT.

Secondary claims also touched by this protocol include LotS-F3 (trials as formation mechanism — captured in Phase 2 NRP entries), LotS-H1 (heart as the affective center through which all formation passes — tested by the correlation between PSFA heart-dimension scores and overall stage progression), and LotS-W1 (wisdom development activated by affective desire — tested by the correlation between STI-A trust scores and the emergence of discernment language in later NRP entries).

Discussion Questions for Small Groups

Section 3 Discussion Questions

1. The protocol requires a twelve-month commitment to weekly PROAPT and monthly narrative reflection. What would need to be true about a small group or church community for that kind of commitment to be sustainable? What has prevented that level of commitment in your own experience?
2. The protocol identifies four baseline dimensions: Affective Taxonomy stage, scripture trust, Image of God profile, and spiritual discipline frequency. If you were to assess your own baseline honestly today, where would you place yourself on each? Which dimension feels most alive, and which most stagnant?
3. The External Witness Interview asks someone who knows the participant well to describe what they have observed in them, without knowing the participant's self-report scores. Who in your life would you choose as your external witness? What do you think they would say about the consistency between your stated beliefs and your actual life?
4. The protocol predicts that the most significant formation events will occur during the active middle phase — and that they will typically involve a specific trial or cost. Looking back at your own spiritual formation, when was the last time a specific challenge accelerated your growth? What happened? What did it cost?
5. The Narrative Reflection Protocol asks four monthly questions: a moment of hearing the word freshly, the impact of a trial, a specific heart change, and evidence of Image of God growth. Try answering all four questions for the current month. What does that exercise reveal about where your formation is most alive right now?

Section 4: Small Group Spiritual Formation Testing Protocol

The Group Is Not Incidental — It Is the Method

When I think back to what made the original Laws of the Spirit workshop actually work, it was not primarily the questions we were asking, as good as some of them were. It was the four of us in the room together, week after week, refusing to let each other get away with vague spiritual generalities. Tom would push back on a principle with a counter-example from his own experience. Larry would bring a scripture that complicated what we thought we had settled the week before. John would ask the uncomfortable practical question — so what does that mean you are going to do differently on Monday morning? That kind of friction, sustained over time, produced discernment that none of us could have arrived at alone.

The small group is not a delivery mechanism for the Laws of the Spirit. It is the primary testing environment. Individual formation happens in the context of community, is confirmed by it, and is often triggered by its dynamics. The PROAPT model's final step — Tell — is not an afterthought; it is the completion of the formation loop. Faith comes from hearing (Romans 10:17), and the small group is where much of that hearing happens: hearing the word, hearing each other's responses to the word, hearing what the Spirit is saying to this particular community in this particular moment.

VOL 2 CONNECTION — SESSION LITURGY: Vol 2 develops V2.Exp8B (Session Liturgy) as the companion claim to V2.Exp8's container claim. The session — the gathered time when a group meets to do this work together, with its front-notes, formally-marked opening, clearings, work, formally-marked closing, and teachings — is the unit of analysis the small group testing protocol is actually observing. Vol 2's canonical claim is that these are not optional checklist items but sequenced moves within one practice; the integrity of the sequence is what makes the work the work. For Vol 4's Small Group Testing Protocol, this has two practical implications. First, the protocol's unit of observation should be the session-as-a-whole, not the discrete components — a session with strong opening and clearings but weak closing dissipates the formation it produced, and the protocol needs to be able to see that. Second, the LotS group health indicators may need to be cross-tabulated against session-liturgy integrity (were opening and closing formally marked? were the clearings substantive? did the closing include the de-rolling and the integrating-into-life moves?) as a predictor variable for the formation outcomes the GSFP tracks. The convergence between Schwarz's communal-qualities instrument and Vol 2's V2.Exp8B session-liturgy structure is a natural area for the multi-site research design to test.

Section 3 described the Individual Spiritual Formation Testing Protocol — how to track and assess formation in one person over twelve months. Section 4 describes the Small Group Testing Protocol: how to observe and assess the group as a formation unit, how to measure what the group produces that individual formation cannot produce on its own, and how to account for the group's collective journey as a distinct object of study. This section also addresses Open Trail OT-6 — the question of whether a community can be understood to move through the Affective Taxonomy as a collective entity — which was left unresolved in Volume 3.

4a. Defining the Small Group Testing Unit

The standard LotS small-group testing unit consists of five to seven participants meeting weekly for 90 minutes using the PROAPT model over a minimum 12-month period. These parameters are not arbitrary. Five to seven is the group size that allows every member to share in every session without the group becoming either a private conversation between two people or a

passive audience for one. Ninety minutes is long enough to move through all six PROAPT steps with genuine depth — the Observe and Apply stages in particular require time that shorter formats compress into superficiality. And twelve months is the minimum period over which the Affective Taxonomy stage transitions predicted by the LotS framework are likely to become visible at the group level.

The group should be led by a trained facilitator — someone who understands the Affective Taxonomy, knows the PROAPT model well enough to hold the structure without strangling the Spirit's work within it, and is themselves at Stage 3 or above on the Affective Taxonomy. The facilitator requirement is discussed in more detail in section 4e below, but it is stated here because it is a constraint on the testing unit itself: a group led by a Stage 1 or Stage 2 facilitator is not testing the LotS small group protocol. It is testing an under-resourced approximation of it.

The group composition that best serves the research program is a realistic cross-section of the church population — not a hand-picked group of unusually committed disciples, but a group drawn from the full range of spiritual development stages present in any healthy congregation. Hawkins and Parkinson's (2011) MOVE study found that church populations characteristically cluster at the four growth stages in roughly equal proportions, with fewer people at the most advanced stage. A research group that reflects this distribution — one or two participants at Stage 1, two at Stage 2, two at Stage 3, and one approaching Stage 4 — is both more realistic and more interesting than a homogeneous group, because it allows the protocol to observe how formation dynamics play out across the full range of starting positions simultaneously.

4b. Open Trail OT-6: Can a Group Move Through the Affective Taxonomy?

Open Trail OT-6, identified in Volume 3, asks whether a community — a small group, a congregation — can be understood to move through the Affective Taxonomy as a collective entity. The individual Affective Taxonomy is well-grounded: it describes the progressive internalization of a value (in the LotS context, trust in scripture and alignment with the image of God) in a single person's affective life. But can something analogous happen at the group level? Can a group, as a group, move from Receiving to Responding to Valuing to Organization to Characterization?

The working hypothesis proposed here is yes, with two important qualifications. The first qualification is that group-level stage progression is not the same as the average of individual progressions. A group of seven people, four of whom have moved from Stage 2 to Stage 3 over twelve months, has not simply achieved a higher average score. Something has happened to the group's culture, its shared language, its collective willingness to engage in the Word at personal cost. The quality of the group's life together has changed. That change is observable and meaningful, and it is not fully captured by aggregating individual scores.

The second qualification is that the group's collective stage is disproportionately influenced by two factors: the facilitator's stage and the group's most advanced members. This is consistent with what we know about community formation dynamics from both social psychology and scripture: groups tend to be pulled upward toward their most formation-mature members, and facilitators set the ceiling for the depth of vulnerability and application that the group will risk. A Stage 4 facilitator creates a group culture in which Stage 3 behavior is normalized and Stage 4 behavior is modeled. A Stage 2 facilitator creates a group culture in which intellectual engagement is the ceiling.

Working Definition: Group Affective Taxonomy Stage

The Group Affective Taxonomy Stage (GATS) is defined as the highest stage at which consistent, habitual group-level behaviors are observed across the majority of sessions. It is not an average of individual stages. It reflects the stage that characterizes the group's shared culture — the level of engagement with the word, vulnerability in application, and willingness to be changed that has become normal in this group.

A group at GATS Stage 3 is a group in which personal conviction, repentance, and costly application are normal parts of every session — not occasional dramatic events but the expected texture of the conversation.

4c. The Group Spiritual Formation Profile (GSFP)

The Group Spiritual Formation Profile is a visual mapping tool that shows the distribution of individual Affective Taxonomy stages within the group at any given assessment point. It is updated quarterly by the facilitator, based on their Stage assessment of each participant, and serves as the primary instrument for tracking the group's collective development over the twelve-month period.

The GSFP is not a ranking of group members — it is never shared with the group in a way that identifies individuals by stage. Its purpose is to give the facilitator and research coordinator a picture of the group's composition and how it is evolving. A GSFP that shows, at Month 3, three participants at Stage 2 and two at Stage 3, and that shows, at Month 12, those same two at Stage 3 and three at Stage 3 with two approaching Stage 4, is telling a story about collective formation that no single participant's individual arc could tell alone.

Assessment Point	Stage Distribution (example)	Group Affective Taxonomy Stage
Baseline (Month 1)	2× Stage 1 3× Stage 2 1× Stage 3 1× Stage 4	GATS: Stage 2
Mid-point (Month 6)	0× Stage 1 2× Stage 2 3× Stage 3 1× Stage 4	GATS: Stage 3 (emerging)
Endpoint (Month 12)	0× Stage 1 1× Stage 2 2× Stage 3 3× Stage 4 1× Stage 5	GATS: Stage 3–4

The example GSFP above illustrates the kind of movement the LotS protocol predicts: a net upward shift across the group, with the most advanced participants continuing to grow and the least advanced participants moving into genuine engagement (Stage 2 to Stage 3 transition) over the course of the year. It also illustrates a realistic complexity: not every participant moves at the same rate, and at Month 12, the group still has one participant at Stage 2. That participant's presence in the group is not a failure of the protocol. A Stage 2 participant embedded in a Stage 3 group culture is exposed, week after week, to the normalized behaviors of the next stage, which is exactly the formation environment the LotS framework predicts will eventually catalyze their own transition.

INSTRUMENT CROSS-REFERENCE — NCD's 3 Colors of Community: A specific external validity check is worth naming here as a concrete action item for the multi-site research design. Schwarz's The 3 Colors of Community (ChurchSmart, 2012) includes an empirically-developed communal test instrument that assesses small group health across seven communal qualities — mapped, in Schwarz's framework, against the seven deadly sins as their corresponding blockage counterparts. The overlap with Vol 2's emotional knots framework is not incidental: where Vol 2 identifies the ways individual affective distortions obstruct formation, Schwarz's seven communal qualities identify the collective-level analogs — the patterns of group dysfunction that prevent a community from becoming the formation environment it is meant to be.

VOL 2 CONNECTION — STANDING INTERIOR AGREEMENTS: Vol 2 introduces V2.Exp2C (Standing Interior Agreements) as a sibling claim under V2.Exp2, naming the upstream binding agent that produces and re-produces emotional knots across multiple blockage-types over years and decades. The agreement is operationally distinct from a knot: a knot is what the participant is carrying; an agreement is what the participant has committed to carrying. A single standing agreement may produce grief knots, shame knots, fear knots, anger knots, and sin-channel behaviors all from the same underlying binding. For the Vol 4 testing program this matters in two specific ways. First, the GSFP and STI-A measurement scaffolding tracks knot-level patterns; the v5_6_0 framing suggests that the LotS protocol may need a complementary instrument for agreement-level patterns, since knot-level interventions may show transient effects (six-month or twelve-month re-formation of cleared patterns) when an upstream agreement is still in force. Second, the Schwarz communal-qualities instrument's identification of group-dysfunction patterns may map not only to Vol 2's knot framework (individual affective distortion) but also to V2.Exp2C's agreement framework (the collective standing agreements a group has entered about who they are, what they are permitted to be, how they are loyal to the group system). Group-level standing agreements are an open hypothesis the multi-site testing program could investigate.

Administering both the GSFP and the NCD 3 Colors of Community communal instrument to the same groups in any multi-site study would allow the research team to assess convergent validity between the two instruments. If a group that the GSFP identifies as formation-blocked also scores low on the relevant NCD communal quality, that convergence would provide evidence that the two instruments are measuring related constructs from different angles. If they diverge, that divergence is equally informative — it would indicate that the GSFP is capturing something the NCD instrument misses, or vice versa. Either result advances the measurement program. This is a low-cost addition to the research design and a high-return one.

4d. Group-Level Outcome Variables

The small group testing protocol tracks five group-level outcome variables over the twelve-month period. These are distinct from the individual outcome variables described in Section 3, though they are correlated with them. They describe what is happening to the group as a unit — its shared culture, its collective behaviors, and its effectiveness as a formation community.

Group Outcome Variable 1: Net Stage Progression Across the Group

The primary group-level outcome variable is the net upward movement of Affective Taxonomy stages across all participants over the twelve-month period. This is calculated as the sum of all positive stage movements across the group, minus any negative movements (stage regression, which can occur during periods of significant trial or spiritual crisis). A group with seven

participants, in which five show positive stage movement of at least one stage transition each, is performing strongly on this variable.

This variable directly tests LotS-H3 and LotS-H4 at the group level: if reflective bible study in community produces the progressive heart formation the Affective Taxonomy describes, then PROAPT groups should show meaningfully greater net stage progression than comparable groups not engaged in structured reflective bible study. The multi-site research design proposed in Section 5 is built around this comparison.

Group Outcome Variable 2: Group Cohesion and Psychological Safety

Stage 3 formation — the transition from intellectual engagement to personal commitment — requires a specific quality of group environment: enough trust and safety for a participant to share a personal conviction, acknowledge a sin, or report a costly behavioral change without fear of judgment or embarrassment. A group that remains at a surface level of politeness — where no one ever takes a real personal risk — is not a Stage 3 group, regardless of what the participants' individual PSFA scores say.

Group cohesion is assessed quarterly using an adapted Group Cohesion Scale (GCS), a brief validated instrument drawn from the group therapy literature and modified for a spiritual formation context. The GCS asks participants to rate the degree to which they feel genuinely known by the group, safe to share honestly, and supported in their formation journey. A rising GCS score over the twelve-month period is both an outcome of the formation process and a precondition for the deeper stages of formation — the two are mutually reinforcing.

The cohesion variable also functions as an early warning system. A group whose GCS scores are declining or flat at Month 6 is unlikely to produce Stage 3-level formation in its remaining six months without a significant intervention. The facilitator's observation notes and the Session Observation Protocol data from this period should be examined carefully to identify what is preventing the development of the psychological safety that Stage 3 formation requires.

Group Outcome Variable 3: Epistemic Trust in the Group Process

The LotS framework proposes, drawing from Campbell et al.'s (2021) epistemic trust model, that the group itself becomes a trusted source of communal discernment over time — not just a context in which individuals hear scripture, but a community whose collective reading of scripture and life is trusted as a source of formation guidance. This is the communal dimension of the Romans 10 chain: sending, preaching, hearing, believing — and the hearing happens, in part, through the voices of trusted community members speaking the word into specific life situations.

Epistemic trust in the group process is assessed through two items added to the quarterly GCS: one item asking whether the participant trusts the group's collective discernment as a source of guidance for their own life decisions, and one item asking whether they have acted on something the group discerned together in the past quarter. Movement on these two items over twelve months is a group-level indicator of the developing communal trust that the LotS framework predicts will emerge in a maturing PROAPT group.

Group Outcome Variable 4: The Tell Rate

The PROAPT model's final step — Tell — asks every participant to name who they will tell about what they heard from the word this week, and to report back the following week on whether they told them. The Tell step is both a formation practice and a research observable: it is the point at which the formation that happened in the group room crosses the threshold into the participant's ordinary life and begins to operate in the Romans 10 chain.

The Tell Rate is defined as the percentage of participants, across all sessions, who complete the Tell step — both naming a person and reporting back on the conversation. A group with a high Tell Rate is a group in which the word is being carried outward from the formation community into the wider world. A group with a low Tell Rate is a group in which the formation is staying in the room. The Tell Rate is tracked by the facilitator in the Session Observation Protocol and reported monthly.

The Tell Rate is also sensitive to the group stage. At Stage 2, participants are often reluctant to Tell — sharing their scripture engagement with someone outside the group feels vulnerable and potentially awkward. At Stage 3, participants begin to Tell naturally, because they are beginning to live from the Word rather than just engaging with it intellectually. At Stage 4 and 5, Tell is not a prompted exercise but a habit: these participants are continuously, without being asked, bringing the word to bear on the conversations of their daily lives. Rising Tell Rates over the twelve-month period are therefore a reasonable proxy for group-level stage progression.

Group Outcome Variable 5: Fruit Observed by External Witnesses

The final group-level outcome variable is the most demanding and the most interesting: evidence of the fruit of the Spirit (Gal. 5:22–23) visible to people outside the group. Love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control — these are Stage 4 and Stage 5 indicators, and they are most reliably observed not by the person exhibiting them (who is often the last to notice) and not by the formation group (who may be too close to the person to see clearly), but by the people in the participant's ordinary life who have no stake in the research program and no reason to be generous in their assessment.

The External Witness Interviews described in Section 3 aggregate across the group to produce a group-level picture. If, at Month 12, six of seven participants' external witnesses independently report observable character changes that they attribute to the participant's deepened spiritual engagement, that is a strong group-level indicator that the formation process is producing the outcomes the LotS framework predicts. If the external witnesses report that nothing has changed — or, more troublingly, that the participant has become more self-righteous or less relationally available since joining the group — that is a finding that demands honest examination.

4e. The Facilitator as a Critical Variable

FORMATION DOCUMENT CONNECTION: *This section's central claim — that the facilitator is the single most important variable in whether a PROAPT small group produces genuine formation — is the operational premise of the Formation Companion paper (FC) in Vol 5. FC's Companion I threshold names Affective Stage 3 as the minimum, corresponding to Section 4e's first facilitator requirement. The six-month PROAPT practice and ongoing supervision requirements below go beyond FC's stated Companion I threshold and should be read as Vol 4's operational additions to FC's baseline, not restatements of it.*

I want to be direct about something that research designs often soften: the facilitator is probably the single most important variable in whether a PROAPT small group produces genuine formation. Not the curriculum, not the assessment instruments, not the group composition — the person in the room who holds the space, models what engagement with the word looks like from the inside, and creates the conditions in which the Stage 2-to-3 transition becomes possible.

This is consistent with the Image of God framework from Volume 3. The facilitator is not just a discussion leader. They are an under-shepherd of God's kingdom in this particular formation context — responsible, as Kilner's Rulership dimension describes, to steward the spiritual growth of the people in their care in alignment with God's purposes. A facilitator who is

themselves at Stage 2 of the Affective Taxonomy — for whom scripture is interesting but not yet personally binding — cannot facilitate Stage 3 formation in others, because they cannot model what it looks like to let the word cost something.

Facilitator Formation Requirements

The LotS testing protocol requires that all group facilitators meet three criteria before leading a research group. First, they must be assessed at Stage 3 or above on the Affective Taxonomy, confirmed by both self-report and an observer who knows them well. A Stage 3 facilitator can lead a group that includes Stage 4 participants — the Spirit's work is not limited by the facilitator's stage — but a facilitator below Stage 3 cannot reliably model the behaviors that the protocol is trying to produce.

Second, they must have completed a minimum of six months of their own PROAPT practice before leading a research group. PROAPT facilitation requires a kind of dual attention — to the scripture text, to the group's dynamics, to the Spirit's movement in the room, to the individual needs of each participant — that only develops through sustained practice. A facilitator who is learning PROAPT at the same time as they are leading a research group is not testing the LotS protocol; they are running a pilot of an undertrained facilitator.

Third, they must be receiving supervision from a more formation-mature practitioner throughout the research period — a spiritual director, a senior pastor, or a peer supervision group of facilitators who meet monthly to share observations and receive challenge and support. The supervision requirement is both a methodological safeguard (it catches facilitator drift and blind spots before they affect the group's formation) and a formation requirement: the facilitator's own journey does not pause while they are leading others.

The Facilitator's Own Affective Taxonomy Stage as an Independent Variable

The research protocol treats the facilitator's Affective Taxonomy stage as a formal independent variable. At the beginning of the study, each facilitator is assessed using the PSFA and the observer-report process described in Section 3. Their stage is documented and held constant as a variable in the analysis of group-level outcomes. The prediction — and this is an Open Trail worth testing formally — is that groups led by Stage 4 facilitators will show significantly greater net stage progression over twelve months than groups led by Stage 3 facilitators, even when all other variables (group composition, church context, PROAPT fidelity) are controlled.

This prediction is not a criticism of Stage 3 facilitators. Stage 3 is a genuinely transformative stage of formation, and a Stage 3 facilitator brings real gifts to a group — the lived experience of what it costs to begin organizing life around biblical values, the fresh memory of the Stage 2-to-3 transition that may be happening for participants around them. But Stage 4 brings something different: the stability and integration that comes from having organized the entire value system around scripture, from which a different quality of presence and patience is possible. The distinction is worth testing, not assuming.

4f. The Session Observation Protocol

The Session Observation Protocol (SOP) is a structured one-page checklist that the facilitator completes after every PROAPT session. It takes five to ten minutes and is designed to capture the formation-relevant dynamics of the session in a form that can be aggregated across sessions and analyzed over time.

The SOP tracks six session-level variables: (1) the number of participants who engaged substantively in the Observe step — asking factual questions, making connections between the text and prior sessions; (2) the number who shared personal applications in the Apply step that

reflected genuine personal cost or conviction; (3) the number who reported a Tell from the previous week; (4) the number who named a specific person for this week's Tell; (5) any significant emotional moment in the session — a moment of visible conviction, repentance, or breakthrough that the facilitator identifies as a potential stage transition indicator; and (6) the facilitator's overall rating of the session's depth of formation engagement on a five-point scale.

The SOP data builds into a session-by-session formation record for each group. Plotted over twelve months, the SOP scores tell a story: groups that begin with low Apply and Tell scores and gradually develop richer personal engagement are tracking the Stage 2-to-3 movement that the LotS protocol predicts. Groups whose SOP scores are flat or declining after Month 3 are signaling that something in the group's formation environment is not working, and the qualitative data from the facilitator's supervision notes should be examined to understand what.

4g. The Collective Spiritual Formation Assessment

In addition to the individual PSFA scores and the facilitator's GSFP tracking, the testing protocol includes a brief Collective Spiritual Formation Assessment (CSFA) administered to the group as a whole at the three formal assessment points: baseline, Month 6, and Month 12. The CSFA asks participants to evaluate the group itself — not their own formation, but what they observe in the group's shared culture and collective life with scripture.

The CSFA has twelve items organized into three domains. The first domain assesses the group's corporate engagement with scripture: do participants experience the group's reading and discussion of the word as qualitatively different from reading alone? Do they find that the group hears things they would not have heard individually? The second domain assesses the group's corporate trust and safety: do participants feel genuinely known, genuinely safe to share their formation journey, and genuinely accountable to the group's collective discernment? The third domain assesses the group's outward orientation: is the formation that happens in the room crossing the threshold into the participants' daily lives, relationships, and communities?

The CSFA is administered anonymously, and results are shared with the group in aggregate at the Month 6 and Month 12 check-in sessions. This shared feedback is itself a formation practice: a group that can look honestly at its own CSFA scores — noting where its corporate life is strong and where it is thin — and discuss those results with humility and curiosity, is exhibiting Stage 3 behaviors at the group level. A group that receives CSFA feedback defensively, or that cannot discuss its collective weaknesses without becoming conflictual, is showing the facilitator exactly what formation work remains to be done.

4h. The Testing Timeline for Small Groups

The small-group testing timeline mirrors the individual timeline's three-phase structure while adding group-level assessment events and a layer of facilitator-side data collection that has no individual parallel.

Phase 1 — Group Formation and Baseline (Months 1–3)

The group's first three months are foundational in a double sense: both the individual participants are establishing their formation baselines (as described in Section 3), and the group itself is forming as a community. These two processes interact. The quality of the group's formation as a community — the degree to which psychological safety develops, the degree to which the Tell step becomes normal, the degree to which participants begin to trust the group's discernment — is both a precondition for and a product of the individual formation happening within it.

The facilitator's primary task in Phase 1 is to model PROAPT discipline without over-controlling the group's responses, to establish the norms of honest sharing and genuine application that will define the group's culture for the next twelve months, and to notice — with as much accuracy as possible — where each participant is starting. The GSFP is first populated at the end of Month 1, updated at the end of Month 3.

The CSFA baseline is administered at the end of Month 1, before the group has had time to develop much shared history. This early baseline captures each participant's initial experience of the group and serves as the reference point for measuring the group's collective development. Groups whose Month 1 CSFA scores already show high trust and safety have likely been formed by prior shared history — the participants may know each other well from other church contexts. This is a variable to document, because it affects the trajectory of the group's formation differently than a group of relative strangers finding their way toward trust for the first time.

Phase 2 — Group Deepening (Months 4–9)

By Month 4, the group should have moved past the initial politeness and orientation of Phase 1 into a rhythm of genuine engagement. The SOP data from Phase 2 is the richest seam of formation evidence in the entire protocol: session by session, the facilitator is documenting the specific moments of Apply and Tell, the specific emotional breakthroughs, the specific instances of personal risk-taking with the word.

The Month 6 assessment point is a significant event for both the group and individuals. The GSFP is updated, the individual PSFAs and STI-As are administered, and the CSFA is administered to the group. The facilitator then prepares a brief Group Formation Review — a one-to-two-page narrative summary of the group's journey to date, identifying the most significant formation moments, the current Group Affective Taxonomy Stage, and the primary formation opportunities and obstacles for the remaining six months. This review is shared with the research coordinator and forms the basis for the facilitator's supervision conversation at Month 6.

Open Trail OT-5 — the question of what precedes instantaneous or dramatic heart change — is most likely to yield data during Phase 2. If any participant in the group experiences a significant formation breakthrough during this period (a dramatic conviction, a sudden reorganization of values, an unexpected surge of Stage 3 or Stage 4 behavior), the protocol calls for a brief supplementary interview with that participant within two weeks of the event, documenting the conditions that preceded it: what had been happening in their PROAPT engagement, their personal circumstances, their prayer life, their relational context. This interview data is not part of the primary research protocol; it is flagged as supplementary qualitative data for the OT-5 Open Trail.

Phase 3 — Group Integration and Assessment (Months 10–12)

The final three months of the group's testing period have a different quality than the preceding nine. By Month 10, the group has a shared history: shared passages that have marked them, shared moments of vulnerability and breakthrough, shared language for describing the formation journey. The PROAPT sessions during this phase should be the deepest of the year — not because the group is trying harder, but because Stage 3 and Stage 4 formation behaviors have become habitual and the word is landing on ground that has been progressively prepared over nine months of consistent engagement.

The Month 12 endpoint assessment completes all individual instruments (PSFA, STI-A, Image of God 4Rs) and adds the CSFA endpoint administration and the facilitator's final GSFP update.

The facilitator also completes a Final Group Formation Report — a narrative document of three to five pages describing the group's twelve-month journey, the key formation events and transitions observed, the current Group Affective Taxonomy Stage, and the facilitator's assessment of which aspects of the PROAPT protocol were most and least effective in producing the outcomes the LotS framework predicted.

The External Witness Interviews are conducted during Months 11 and 12. The research coordinator aggregates the EWI data across the group and presents the group-level summary (without individual identification) to the facilitator and, at the group's discretion, to the group itself. The aggregate EWI data — what the people who know these participants best observed in them over the year — is the most honest mirror the group will encounter of whether its formation produced the fruit it was aiming for.

4i. The Claims This Protocol Tests

The small group testing protocol tests several LotS claims that the individual protocol cannot reach on its own, as well as providing a community-level confirmation of the claims tested individually.

LotS-F4 — Community is essential to faith formation (the Romans 10 chain). The group protocol tests this directly: does PROAPT community produce formation outcomes that cannot be attributed to the individual's own discipline practice alone? The comparison between individual SDFL discipline frequency and group-level SOP Tell Rate scores should show that the group's communal engagement with the word adds something above and beyond what any participant would produce in private.

LotS-H2 — Unrepentant sin progressively hardens the heart. The group protocol tests this as a qualitative theme: do the NRP narratives and EWI interviews reveal patterns in which participants who are carrying unresolved sin show consistently slower stage progression? This is a sensitive and ethically demanding area of investigation, and the protocol handles it through aggregate qualitative coding rather than individual attribution.

OT-6 (Collective formation) — The group protocol is specifically designed to test whether the Group Affective Taxonomy Stage construct is meaningful and useful: does it predict individual formation outcomes better than individual starting stages alone? Does the facilitator stage predict group GATS trajectory? Does the CSFA's corporate engagement domain correlate with the Tell Rate and net stage progression?

LotS-SF1 and LotS-SF2 — Spiritual force and energy. The group protocol contributes to these claims through the aggregate EWI data and the facilitator's Final Group Formation Report: do groups at higher average stages show qualitatively different levels of spiritual vitality — more Tell activity, more fruit observed by external witnesses, more evidence of the word operating in the participants' daily lives — than groups at lower stages? The spiritual force claims are the hardest in the LotS framework to operationalize, and the group protocol is where the most interesting qualitative data about them is likely to emerge.

Discussion Questions for Small Groups

Section 4 Discussion Questions

- 1.** The section argues that the small group is not just a delivery mechanism for the Laws of the Spirit — it is the primary testing environment. What has been your experience of a small

group that genuinely functioned as a testing community? What made it different from groups that were merely social or informational?

2. The Group Affective Taxonomy Stage (GATS) concept proposes that a group has a collective formation stage that is distinct from the average of individual stages. Do you agree that groups have a collective spiritual culture that is more than the sum of their members? What examples from your experience would you use to argue for or against this?

3. The section argues that the facilitator is probably the single most important variable in whether a PROAPT group produces genuine formation — more important than curriculum, instruments, or group composition. How does this land for you? What are the implications for how a church invests in developing formation-capable facilitators?

4. The Tell Rate — the percentage of participants who complete the PROAPT Tell step — is proposed as a proxy for group-level stage progression. What has been your experience of the Tell step in small groups you have participated in? Has it felt like a natural completion of the formation loop, or an awkward add-on? What would it take for Tell to become habitual?

5. The External Witness Interview — asking someone outside the group to describe what they have observed in participants — is described as "the most honest mirror the group will encounter of whether its formation produced the fruit it was aiming for." If you were to ask the most honest person in your life to describe the fruit of the Spirit they observe in you, what do you think they would say? What would you most want them to be able to say in a year's time?

Section 5: Research Program Design for Spiritual Formation

From Protocol to Program

Sections 3 and 4 described what to measure and how to measure it — in an individual over twelve months, and in a small group over the same period. Section 5 asks the harder question: how do you build a research program that can say something meaningful, not just about this group in this church in this season, but about the Laws of the Spirit as a set of claims that hold — or do not hold — across persons, contexts, and time?

The step from protocol to program is not just a matter of scaling. It introduces methodological demands that the individual and group protocols alone cannot satisfy: the need for comparison conditions, the need for sufficient sample sizes to support statistical analysis, the need for site diversity that allows claims to be distinguished from local church culture effects, and the need for longitudinal depth that allows the slow work of Affective Taxonomy stage progression to become visible against the noise of ordinary life variation. These demands are real, and this section takes them seriously.

At the same time, I want to hold onto something that can easily get lost when a personal exploration enters the academy: the research program proposed here is not an end in itself. It is a service to the original question — the one that started with a Saturday morning workshop group in 2002 and has been working its way through other groups I have been involved in using scripture, reason, experience, and community ever since. Does the spiritual world operate according to regular, discoverable laws? The research program is one more attempt to find out — the most rigorous attempt the LotS project has yet made. But the question it is trying to answer is the same one it has always been.

5a. The Five Primary Research Questions

The research program is organized around five primary research questions. Each question is testable with the instruments and protocols described in Sections 3 and 4; each maps to one or more specific LotS claims; and each is designed to yield findings that are meaningful whether they confirm or challenge the framework.

Research Question 1 (Primary)

RQ1: Does consistent participation in PROAPT-based small group bible study produce measurable movement through the Affective Taxonomy stages over a 12-month period, compared to a matched control group?

LotS Claims Tested: LotS-H3, LotS-H4, LotS-F4

Primary Instruments: PSFA (Stage progression), SOP (Tell Rate), GSFP (Group stage distribution)

Expected Finding: PROAPT participants will show significantly greater net stage progression than control participants over 12 months.

Research Question 2

RQ2: Is there a significant positive correlation between Affective Taxonomy stage and scripture trust level (STI-A score) at each assessment point?

LotS Claims Tested: LotS-F1, LotS-F2, LotS-H1

Primary Instruments: PSFA (Stage), STI-A (Scripture trust), NRP (Qualitative confirmation)

Expected Finding: STI-A scores will correlate positively with PSFA stage scores ($r \geq 0.60$) and will rise in parallel with stage progression, with affective changes preceding cognitive changes.

Research Question 3

RQ3: Does Affective Taxonomy stage progression correlate with measurable growth in one or more of the Image of God 4Rs (Reason, Rulership, Relationship, Righteousness)?

LotS Claims Tested: LotS-I2, LotS-I3

Primary Instruments: PSFA (Stage), Image of God 4Rs Self-Assessment, NRP (4R-specific prompts)

Expected Finding: Participants progressing to Stage 3 and above will show significant growth in at least two 4R dimensions; specific 4Rs will correspond to the scriptural content engaged in their PROAPT group.

Research Question 4

RQ4: Does the facilitator's own Affective Taxonomy stage predict the group's net stage progression rate and Group Affective Taxonomy Stage (GATS) trajectory?

LotS Claims Tested: OT-6 (Collective formation), Volume 3 Leadership application

Primary Instruments: Facilitator PSFA (baseline), GSFP (quarterly), Final Group Formation Report

Expected Finding: Groups led by Stage 4 facilitators will show significantly greater net stage progression than groups led by Stage 3 facilitators, controlling for group composition and church context.

Research Question 5

RQ5: Are there identifiable preconditions — in PROAPT engagement, personal circumstances, or relational context — that reliably precede dramatic or rapid stage transitions?

LotS Claims Tested: OT-5 (Precursors of instantaneous heart change), LotS-F3 (Trials as formation mechanism)

Primary Instruments: NRP (Monthly narratives), OT-5 Supplementary Interview, SOP (Facilitator session notes)

Expected Finding: Rapid stage transitions will be consistently preceded by a period of heightened PROAPT engagement combined with a significant trial or cost, confirming Jas. 1:2-3 as a mechanism rather than a coincidence.

5b. Research Design

The LotS research program employs a longitudinal mixed-methods design with a quasi-experimental comparison condition. The choice of design reflects the epistemological framework established in Section 2: the complexity of spiritual formation outcomes requires both quantitative tracking of behavioral change and qualitative depth in understanding what that change means and how it occurred. Neither alone is adequate; together they provide the multi-layered picture of formation that the LotS claims require.

Overall Design Structure

The program runs for a minimum of twenty-four months across three phases: a six-month preparation and recruitment phase, a twelve-month active study period (the individual and group protocols described in Sections 3 and 4), and a six-month analysis and reporting phase. The extended preparation phase is not optional padding — it is the time required to recruit and train facilitators, establish research partnerships with participating churches, adapt and pilot-test the assessment instruments, and ensure that the ethical framework described in section 5d is in place before any participant data is collected.

The active study period is the twelve months described in Sections 3 and 4. During this period, data collection happens through the instruments already described: PSFA, STI-A, Image of God 4Rs, SDFL, NRP, SOP, GCS, CSFA, and EWI. No new data collection instruments are introduced mid-study; this is a constraint that protects the study's integrity and reduces participant burden.

Sites and Groups

The research program targets three to five participating churches across different demographic and theological contexts. Site diversity is essential for the LotS program's ambition to say something about the Laws of the Spirit that transcends any single church culture. A finding that

holds at a theologically conservative suburban congregation, a mid-size urban multiethnic congregation, and a smaller rural church is meaningfully more robust than a finding from a single site, however well-designed that site's study is.

The aspiration to multi-site, eventually international research is not unprecedented in Christian spiritual formation research, and naming the closest existing model is useful both for credibility and for realistic planning. Christian Schwarz's original NCD study — published in 1996 as the empirical foundation of Natural Church Development — began in German-speaking Europe with 120 churches, published the findings, and built from there through a staged growth model: local pilot, then multi-site domestic study, then international partnership. By 2016, the NCD Church Survey had been administered to more than 70,000 churches across 84 countries and 112 denominations. Schwarz did not design a 70,000-church study. He designed a 120-church study rigorously, published results that warranted replication, and let the research program grow into its international scale through the credibility of its findings.

The LotS research trajectory should follow the same logic. The three-to-five site design proposed here is not a scaled-down version of a larger ambition that has been deferred for lack of resources. It is the right first study — the study that, if it produces the results the LotS framework predicts, will provide the warrant for the next stage. A finding that PROAPT groups show meaningfully greater stage progression than comparison cohorts across three to five theologically and demographically diverse sites is the result that invites replication. That invitation, if answered, is how a 120-church study becomes a 70,000-church study over twenty years. The LotS program should be designed from the beginning with that trajectory in mind.

Each site runs two PROAPT research groups simultaneously: one led by a Stage 3 facilitator and one by a Stage 4 facilitator, with comparable group compositions at baseline. This within-site pairing controls for site-level variables (church culture, demographic factors, theological tradition) while testing RQ4 — the facilitator stage question — within the same context. The research coordinator visits each site at least quarterly to conduct instrument administrations, facilitator supervision check-ins, and spot-observation of PROAPT sessions.

Each site also identifies a comparison cohort: church members who are not participating in a PROAPT research group but who agree to complete the PSFA and STI-A at baseline and at Month 12. The comparison cohort is not randomly assigned — it is a quasi-experimental control, drawn from the same church population. Participants in the comparison cohort may be attending other small groups, Sunday school classes, or no formal formation program. Their twelve-month data provides the baseline rate of stage progression in the church population without the PROAPT intervention, which is the denominator against which the PROAPT groups' progression is measured for RQ1.

Site Element	Count per Site	Total (5 sites)	Primary Purpose
PROAPT Research Groups	2	10 groups	Primary intervention condition
Participants per group	6 (avg)	60 active	Individual + group protocols
Facilitators	2 per site	10 total	Stage 3 and Stage 4 pairings
Comparison cohort	10–15	50–75 total	Quasi-experimental control for RQ1
External Witnesses	1 per participant	60 + cohort	Independent behavioral observation

Research Coordinators	1 per site	5 total	Data collection and facilitator support
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Quantitative Analysis Plan

The quantitative analysis addresses RQ1 through RQ4 using the PSFA stage scores, STI-A scores, and Image of God 4Rs assessment scores collected at three time points (baseline, Month 6, Month 12) across PROAPT participants and the comparison cohort.

For RQ1, the primary analysis is a repeated-measures comparison of PSFA stage progression between the PROAPT groups and the comparison cohort over twelve months. Statistical significance is tested using a mixed ANOVA with time as the within-subjects factor and group condition (PROAPT vs. comparison) as the between-subjects factor. The expected finding is a significant time $\times$ condition interaction: PROAPT participants show greater stage progression over time than comparison participants. Effect size will be reported as partial eta-squared; a medium effect ($\eta^2 \geq 0.06$) is the minimum threshold for the finding to be considered practically meaningful given the sample size.

For RQ2, the analysis is a correlation study at each time point: are PSFA stage scores and STI-A trust scores significantly correlated? A Pearson $r \geq 0.60$ is predicted, based on the theoretical relationship between the two constructs. A second analysis examines the temporal ordering of the two measures: does affective stage progression (PSFA) precede scripture trust changes (STI-A) or follow them? This temporal ordering question is addressed using cross-lagged panel analysis across the three time points.

For RQ3, the analysis examines the correlation between PSFA stage progression and Image of God 4Rs profile shifts. A separate analysis examines whether specific 4Rs grow in response to specific scriptural content domains — this requires the facilitator's session notes to document the primary thematic content of each month's PROAPT sessions, allowing the research coordinator to code sessions by 4R domain and test whether 4R growth aligns with content exposure.

For RQ4, the analysis compares net stage progression across groups led by Stage 3 versus Stage 4 facilitators, using a two-sample t-test on net PSFA change scores within each site. Given the small number of groups (two per site, ten total), the analysis will be primarily descriptive and effect-size-based rather than inferential — the sample size is not sufficient to support strong statistical conclusions about the facilitator effect, but a consistent directional pattern across sites will be a meaningful finding that warrants further investigation in a larger study.

Qualitative Analysis Plan

The qualitative analysis addresses RQ5 and provides the interpretive texture for RQ1 through RQ4. Its primary data sources are the twelve months of NRP entries from each participant, the facilitator session observation notes, the OT-5 supplementary interview transcripts, and the EWI interview data.

The NRP entries are analyzed using thematic coding organized around the LotS framework's key constructs: hearing the word (Romans 10:17 mechanism), trial as formation catalyst (James 1:2–3), heart change (Affective Taxonomy stage transitions), and Image of God growth (4R domains). Two coders work independently on a random 30 percent sample of the NRP entries to establish inter-rater reliability before coding the full dataset. Discrepancies are resolved through discussion and a third-coder tiebreak process. The coding scheme is developed

inductively from the data as well as deductively from the LotS framework — findings that do not map onto the existing framework are flagged as potential refinements or challenges to the framework, not discarded.

The EWI data is analyzed separately, with coders working blind to the participant's own PSFA and NRP data. This blind analysis is essential: the value of the EWI is precisely its independence from the participant's self-report. Convergence between the EWI's observations and the participant's own NRP narrative is a validity indicator for both instruments. Divergence — particularly where the participant reports significant heart change that the external witness does not observe — is a flag for what the LotS framework calls the belief-behavior integration gap: Stage 3 formation at the level of intention that has not yet fully crossed into Stage 4 at the level of habitual character.

The OT-5 supplementary interviews with participants who experienced rapid or dramatic stage transitions are analyzed using narrative inquiry methods: each participant tells the story of their formation breakthrough in their own words, and the researcher maps that narrative against the LotS framework's predictions about preconditions. Consistent patterns across multiple supplementary interviews would constitute preliminary evidence for the OT-5 hypothesis — that instantaneous-seeming heart change is characteristically preceded by a period of spiritual preparation that may not be visible to the participant at the time.

5c. Instruments Summary

The table below summarizes all instruments used in the research program, the constructs they measure, the LotS claims they test, their data type, and the frequency of administration. Full draft instruments appear in Appendix A.

Instrument	Construct Measured	LotS Claims	Type	Frequency
PSFA	Affective Taxonomy stage; Image of God 4Rs	H3, H4, I2, I3, F2	Quantitative	Baseline, M6, M12
STI-A	Scripture trust level	F1, F2, H1	Quantitative	Baseline, M6, M12
Image of God 4Rs	4R profile (Reason, Rulership, Relationship, Righteousness)	I2, I3	Quantitative	Baseline, M12
SDFL	Spiritual discipline frequency	H4, contextual	Quantitative	Weekly log
NRP	Formation experience narrative; trial response; heart change; 4R growth	F3, H1, H3, I2, OT-5	Qualitative	Monthly
SOP	Session engagement; Tell Rate; stage-transition events	F4, H4, OT-6	Mixed	Every session

GSFP	Group stage distribution; GATS trajectory	OT-6, H3	Qualitative/Visual	Quarterly
GCS	Group cohesion; psychological safety	F4, OT-6	Quantitative	Quarterly
CSFA	Collective scripture engagement; group trust; outward orientation	F4, OT-6, SF1	Quantitative	Baseline, M6, M12
EWI	External behavioral observation; belief-behavior integration	H3, H4, I2, SF2	Qualitative	Baseline, M12
OT-5 Interview	Preconditions of rapid stage transitions	F3, OT-5	Qualitative	Event-triggered
Facilitator PSFA	Facilitator Affective Taxonomy stage	OT-6, RQ4	Quantitative	Baseline

5d. Ethical Considerations

Research in spiritual formation settings raises ethical questions that standard social science research frameworks address imperfectly. The participants are not just research subjects — they are people entrusting their spiritual journey, their personal convictions, their private struggles with faith, to a process that they are simultaneously trying to live authentically. The researcher is not just an observer — they are, in the LotS framework, themselves a disciple, bringing their own formation history and their own stage on the Affective Taxonomy to every interaction with the data. These realities demand an ethical framework that is more thoughtful than the standard IRB checklist, though that checklist is the minimum, not the ceiling.

Informed Consent in a Pastoral Context

Every participant in the research program — PROAPT group members, comparison cohort members, external witnesses, and facilitators — signs an informed consent document before any data is collected. The consent document describes the research purpose, the data collection methods, the storage and anonymization procedures, the right to withdraw at any time without affecting their participation in the church's regular programming, and the potential risks of participation.

The potential risks in a spiritual formation study are not primarily physical — they are relational and psychological. A participant who shares a personal conviction or a pattern of unrepentant sin in the context of the PROAPT group, and who later regrets that disclosure, cannot fully un-share it. A participant whose EWI reveals a significant belief-behavior gap may find the endpoint interview conversation uncomfortable or even painful. A participant who grows in internalization may cause external relationships (such as a spouse) outside the research group to be uncomfortable and cause the participant to suppress development. The consent document names these risks explicitly and describes the support available: the facilitator is trained to respond pastorally to distress that arises in the group context, and the research coordinator maintains a referral list of pastoral counselors at each site.

The consent process for external witnesses deserves special attention. External witnesses are asked to describe, in an interview, what they have observed about the participant over the past 12 months. They may not know that the participant is in a spiritual formation research program; they may be surprised by the depth of some of the interview questions. The EWI consent process includes a brief explanation of the research purpose and an explicit statement that the interview data will be anonymized before any analysis and will never be shared with the participant in a form that identifies the external witness by name.

Protecting Vulnerable Participants

Three categories of participants require particular care in the LotS research program.

Participants in the early stages of faith (Stage 1–2). The assessment process — particularly the PSFA's direct questions about one's relationship to scripture and the degree to which biblical principles are shaping daily life — can feel exposing or judgmental to a participant who is genuinely at Stage 1: attending out of curiosity, not yet sure what they believe, not yet trusting the group enough to share honestly. The PSFA is framed as a personal reflection tool, not an evaluation. Facilitators are trained to reinforce this framing and to respond to Stage 1 participants' discomfort with pastoral warmth rather than research urgency.

Participants in a spiritual crisis. The formation process can surface pain, loss, unresolved grief, and deep spiritual doubt. A participant who is in acute spiritual crisis — questioning whether God exists, processing a devastating loss, or wrestling with a long-buried sin — is not best served by continued participation in a research protocol. The facilitator protocol includes clear criteria for recognizing acute spiritual crisis and clear procedures for responding: stepping outside the research protocol to offer pastoral care, referring to professional support when appropriate, and supporting the participant's decision to withdraw from the research program without prejudice if that is what they need.

Participants who may feel assessed or judged. The entire vocabulary of the Affective Taxonomy — stages, transitions, progression — can inadvertently communicate that some participants are "better" than others, more spiritually advanced, further along. This is the opposite of the LotS project's intention, and it is the opposite of the Image of God framework's anthropology: every participant is a fully connected image-bearer, whatever stage they are at. The facilitator training program addresses this directly, giving facilitators language for speaking about stage progression in ways that honor the dignity and the particular journey of every participant, at every stage.

The Researcher's Own Formation as an Ethical Commitment

The LotS project has always insisted, from the first workshop group onward, that you cannot study the spiritual life from the outside. This insistence has an ethical dimension that deserves to be named explicitly in the research framework. A researcher who is not themselves engaged in the formation journey — who is observing without practicing, measuring without living — is asking participants to be transparent about their spiritual struggles while maintaining their own opacity. That is not an ethical research relationship.

The research program, therefore, requires that all research coordinators be themselves engaged in a regular formation practice — minimally, personal reflective bible study and participation in a small group — and that they maintain a personal journal of their own formation observations during the study period. This journal is not analyzed as research data; it is the researcher's own formation record, maintained as an act of integrity and a calibration instrument for their interpretive work with the participant data. The most natural small group for a coordinator is the other involved coordinators, if possible.

This requirement will strike some academic researchers as methodologically unusual. It is. It reflects the LotS project's foundational conviction that the spiritual world is not a subject to be studied from a safe distance but a reality to be inhabited — that the Laws of the Spirit, if they are real, are no more observable from the outside than the law of love is observable by someone who has never loved. The research program is built for practitioners who are also rigorous thinkers. That is a narrow target. It is the right one.

5e. Mapping to the Open Trails

Volume 3 identified ten Open Trails — areas where the LotS exploration had pointed but not yet gone. The research program proposed in Section 5 does not resolve all ten, but it makes meaningful progress on six of them. The table below maps each Open Trail to its status in the research program.

Open Trail	Description	Status in This Research Program
OT-1	Test PROAPT-Taxonomy model in real small group with structured assessment	Directly addressed — the core of Sections 3 and 4
OT-2	Extend Affective Taxonomy to full agape triad (love of God and neighbor, fruits of the Spirit)	Partially addressed — EWI and NRP capture agape-adjacent outcomes; full extension requires a second study
OT-3	Complete the taxonomy trilogy — spirit and soul taxonomy parallel to affective and cognitive	Not addressed — this requires a prior theological anthropology study; flagged for future work
OT-4	Map LotS explorations to a discipleship curriculum using Affective Taxonomy as scaffolding	Partially addressed — PROAPT functions as the curriculum scaffold; formal curriculum mapping is a separate project
OT-5	Precursors of instantaneous heart change	Directly addressed — OT-5 Supplementary Interview protocol; RQ5
OT-6	Collective spiritual formation — how a community moves through the Affective Taxonomy	Directly addressed — GATS, GSFP, CSFA, and Group outcome variables in Section 4
OT-7	Image of God renewal as a structured process — 4Rs as developmental milestones	Directly addressed — RQ3, Image of God 4Rs Self-Assessment, NRP 4R prompts
OT-8	Sin's impact on trust development — how unrepentant sin interferes with Affective Taxonomy progression	Partially addressed — NRP qualitative coding includes sin-pattern themes; direct testing requires a different study design
OT-9	Leadership formation through Image of God lens — 3D framework integrating 4Rs, Affective Taxonomy, Cognitive Taxonomy	Partially addressed — RQ4 and facilitator stage as independent variable; full leadership formation study is a separate project

OT-10	Doctrine testing through fruit analysis — evaluating doctrines by their observable fruit	Not directly addressed — this is a meta-level research question that builds on the findings of this program
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The six Open Trails that this research program meaningfully advances — OT-1, OT-5, OT-6, OT-7, and partially OT-2, OT-4, OT-8, and OT-9 — represent the core of the spiritual formation testing work. The remaining trails (OT-3, OT-10, and the full extensions of OT-2, OT-4, OT-8, OT-9) require either prior groundwork not yet done or a scope of research that goes well beyond a twelve-month multi-site study. They remain on the Open Trails list — an invitation to the next researcher, the next workshop group, the next generation of LotS explorers who pick up this work and carry it further.

5f. What a Positive Finding Would Mean — and What It Would Not

I want to close Section 5 with the question that, in my experience, almost never gets asked but should be asked first: if this research program produces positive findings — if PROAPT groups show significantly greater stage progression than comparison participants, if scripture trust and stage progression correlate as predicted, if facilitator stage predicts group outcomes — what would that actually mean?

It would mean that the mechanisms proposed in Volumes 1–3 — reflective bible study in community, progressive heart formation through the Affective Taxonomy stages, growth toward the Image of God through the 4Rs — produce measurable, reproducible outcomes in real people's lives over real time. It would mean that the LotS framework is not just a personal exploration or a theological speculation but a testable model of how the spiritual life works, with enough empirical traction to be refined, replicated, and built upon. It would mean that the original workshop group in 2002 was onto something real.

It would not mean that the Laws of the Spirit are exhaustively described in this series. The LotS project has always been an open exploration, not a closed system. A positive finding from the research program would be an invitation to go deeper, not a declaration that the work is done. It would not mean that the Holy Spirit's work can be reduced to measurable outcomes — the research program captures the traceable shadow of spiritual formation, not its full reality. And it would not mean that any individual who follows the PROAPT model and engages sincerely with the Affective Taxonomy framework is guaranteed specific outcomes on a specific timeline. The Spirit blows where He wishes. The research program is testing whether the conditions proposed by the LotS framework are conditions in which the Spirit characteristically works — not whether they compel Him.

What a negative finding would mean is equally worth stating. If PROAPT groups show no greater stage progression than comparison participants — if the Tell Rate stays flat, if the EWI data shows no observable change in participants' character and behavior, if the NRP narratives are thin and generic after twelve months of weekly engagement — that would be significant disconfirming evidence for LotS-H4, and it would demand a serious re-examination of the framework. Not its abandonment — a single study is not dispositive — but a serious, honest, community-tested re-examination of whether the proposed mechanisms are the right ones.

That is the kind of project the LotS has always been. The test is not just for the data. It is for us.

Discussion Questions for Small Groups

Section 5 Discussion Questions

1. The research program requires three to five participating churches across different demographic and theological contexts. What do you think would be the most significant site-to-site variable affecting the outcomes — theological tradition, demographic composition, church size, the quality of pastoral leadership, or something else? What would you want to hold constant across sites, and what would you deliberately vary?
2. The section describes three categories of vulnerable participant: those in early stages of faith, those in spiritual crisis, and those who may feel judged by the stage language. Have you ever been in a spiritual formation context where the language of growth or development felt more like a ranking system than a journey description? What made it feel that way, and what would have made it feel different?
3. The ethical framework requires that research coordinators be themselves engaged in a regular formation practice during the study period. The author acknowledges this is methodologically unusual. Do you find it convincing or troubling — or both? What would be lost if the researcher were not on the journey themselves?
4. The section closes by distinguishing what a positive finding would mean from what it would not mean. It would not mean that the Holy Spirit's work is reducible to measurable outcomes, and it would not guarantee any individual specific results. Does that honest limiting of the research program's claims increase or decrease your confidence in it? Why?
5. I suggest: 'The test is not just for the data. It is for us.' What do you think this means? Is there a way in which engaging seriously with the LotS testing protocol — as a participant, a facilitator, or a researcher — is itself a formation practice? What might it require of you personally to participate honestly in this kind of research?

